EXB-01 · EXAM BLUEPRINT

Examination blueprint — PCL-AI

What the examination assesses, in what proportion, in what format — and what is not yet fixed

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

Summary

This is the published specification for the PCI AI Project Controls Leader (PCL-AI) examination: the three assessment groups and their 40/40/20 weighting, all thirteen domains and sixty-one knowledge areas that may be sampled, the item format, the cognitive levels, the scoring basis and the duration. It also states plainly what has not yet been fixed — the number of items and the definitive passing standard — and how each will be settled. Read it as the contract between the candidate and the examination: study against it, audit yourself against it, and hold the Institute to it. It covers the PCL-AI only; no examination blueprint exists yet for PFL-AI or PML-AI.

About this document

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Contents

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Who this is for. Candidates preparing for the PCL-AI; training providers building courses against it; employers deciding what a PCL-AI holder was actually assessed on; and assessment professionals auditing whether the Institute's claims about its examination are supported by a published specification.

1. What a blueprint commits us to

A blueprint is not a syllabus with a marketing wrapper. It is the document that makes an examination auditable, and it does three specific things.

It fixes the sampling frame. Every item on every form is drawn from the domains and knowledge areas set out in §5 of this document, at the group weights set out in §4. Content that is not in the frame is not examinable. A candidate who studies the frame has studied the examination; there are no surprise topics and no unpublished content.

It makes forms comparable. Because every form is assembled to the same specification, a pass earned on one form means what a pass earned on another form means. Without a blueprint, "the examination" is whatever questions happened to be selected that month, and comparability across sittings is an assertion rather than a property of the design.

It transfers the burden of proof onto the Institute. Publishing the specification means anyone can check whether our examination does what we say it does. That is uncomfortable by design. An assessment that cannot be inspected cannot be trusted, and the Institute's position is that a certification body which will not publish its blueprint is asking to be taken on faith.

1.1 What this blueprint governs, and what it does not

This blueprint governs	The published certification policies govern
Which domains and knowledge areas may be sampled	Eligibility, application and verification of experience
The group weightings applied to every form	Fees, booking, rescheduling and cancellation
Item format and the cognitive levels items are written to	Identification, proctoring arrangements and accommodations
The scoring basis and how the passing standard is set	Misconduct, appeals, complaints and retakes
The item development, review and retirement process	Recertification, continuing professional development and use of the credential

Where this blueprint and a published policy appear to conflict, the published policy prevails and the conflict is a defect in this document that the Institute wants reported. For the policy side of the table, see `CER-01 — Certification handbook — master`.

2. The credential this covers — and the two it does not

This blueprint applies to the **PCL-AI (PCI AI Project Controls Leader)** only.

The Institute certifies three credentials at Leader level: PCL-AI, PFL-AI (PCI AI Project Finance Leader) and PML-AI (PCI Project Management Leader – AI). **No examination blueprint exists yet for PFL-AI or PML-AI.** There are no published weightings, no published domain structure and no item counts for those two examinations, and nothing in this document should be read as covering them. When their blueprints are developed they will be published in this series under their own identifiers, built by the same process, and subject to their own job-task analysis.

A fourth offering, the **AI in Project Controls — Specialist Certificate (AIPC)**, is a certificate rather than one of the three credentials. It is open-entry, drawn from Domain 13 of the body of knowledge below, and assessed by scenario items plus an applied AI task. It is not governed by this blueprint.

An earlier edition of this blueprint was published under a credential code that has since been retired. Where legacy study material carries that older code, the content it describes is now the PCL-AI; the framework did not change, the name did.

3. The examination at a glance

Element	Specification
Duration	90 minutes
Item format	Four-option multiple choice, single best answer
Number of scored items	[CONFIRM: number of scored items — to be set by the job-task analysis] — see §9.1
Cognitive levels	Recall, Application, Analysis — application-weighted (see EXB-03)
Content sampling	Thirteen domains, sixty-one knowledge areas, in three groups weighted 40/40/20
Scoring	Criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve
Configured pass mark	65 per cent — the definitive standard will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study (see §9.2 and EXB-05)
Formula sheet	**None provided in the examination** (see §7.2)
Result	Issued immediately on submission, with a domain-level breakdown
Interface languages	English, Arabic, Spanish, French, Korean, Chinese, Russian
Proctoring	Live proctoring with identity verification, room scan and second-monitor blocking (see EXB-07)
Launch window	Opens 15 minutes before the booked time, with a 30-minute grace period
Certificate validity	3 years, maintained through continuing professional development with a mandatory AI-currency component

Booking, rescheduling, attempt allowances and fees are governed by the published policies, not by this blueprint; see CER-01.

4. The three groups and the 40/40/20 weighting

Every form is assembled so that the scored content divides across three groups in fixed proportions.

Group	Domains	Knowledge areas	Weight
Project accounting & finance	D1–D4	19	40 %
Project management principles	D5–D12	35	40 %
AI knowledge & practical approach	D13	7	20 %
Total	**13 domains**	**61**	**100 %**

Two things follow from that table, and both matter more than they look.

Weights attach to groups, not to individual domains. The Institute publishes no per-domain percentage and no per-domain passing requirement. Within a group, coverage is spread across its member domains and their knowledge areas; the blueprint constrains the group totals, and the item selection rules constrain the spread within a group so that no domain can be omitted from a form or allowed to dominate it.

The three groups are not equal in size, and the weighting is not proportional to size. Nineteen knowledge areas carry 40 per cent; thirty-five knowledge areas carry the same 40 per cent; seven knowledge areas carry 20 per cent. That is a deliberate measurement decision about what the credential attests, and it has consequences a candidate can compute for their own revision plan. The full defence of the weighting, and the arithmetic of what it does to a score, is in `EXB-02 — Domain weightings and the 40/40/20 rule`.

5. The syllabus: thirteen domains, sixty-one knowledge areas

This is the sampling frame in full. Every knowledge area listed is examinable. The numbering convention is **Domain.KnowledgeArea.Topic** — so `6.2` is the second knowledge area of Domain 6, and `6.2.1` a topic within it. Items are tagged to that level so that domain-level reporting on a result is a fact about the form, not an estimate.

5.1 Group 1 — Project accounting & finance (40 %)

Nineteen knowledge areas across four domains. This group exists because a controls professional who cannot read the accounts cannot reconcile the cost report to them, and a cost report that does not reconcile is an opinion.

Domain	Knowledge areas
D1 — Foundations of Accounting for Project Controls (5)	1.1 The accounting model · 1.2 Components of the financial statements · 1.3 Accrual accounting and the matching concept · 1.4 Cost provisions and cost accruals · 1.5 Chart of accounts and cost coding for projects
D2 — Financial Reporting & the Standards (5)	2.1 The reporting framework · 2.2 IFRS 15 Revenue from Contracts with Customers · 2.3 Revenue recognition beyond the basics · 2.4 Other relevant standards for project controls · 2.5 Management reporting versus statutory reporting
D3 — Budgeting & Forecasting (5)	3.1 Budgeting fundamentals · 3.2 Cost estimation · 3.3 The time-phased budget and cost baseline (planned value) · 3.4 Forecasting · 3.5 Cash-flow forecasting
D4 — Performance Management, Variance Analysis & Management Reporting (4)	4.1 Performance management principles · 4.2 Variance analysis · 4.3 Management reporting · 4.4 Data visualisation and storytelling for controls

Standards are examined at the level a controls professional must actually work with them: the principle, the recognition test, the consequence for the project position and the presentation. Items describe requirements in the Institute's own words. Protected standard text, tables and diagrams are never reproduced in study material or in an item.

5.2 Group 2 — Project management principles (40 %)

Thirty-five knowledge areas across eight domains. This is the discipline itself — cost, earned value, commercial, lifecycle, adaptive delivery, schedule, process cycles and risk.

Domain	Knowledge areas
D5 — Cost Management & Cost Control (4)	5.1 The cost management framework · 5.2 The cost control cycle · 5.3 Cost breakdown and control accounts · 5.4 Change control and cost impact
D6 — Earned Value Management & Forecasting (EVM/EAC) (4)	6.1 EVM fundamentals · 6.2 Variances and performance indices · 6.3 Forecasting with EVM: the estimate-at-completion family · 6.4 Integrating cost and schedule; limitations; earned schedule
D7 — Contracts, Commercial Management, BoQ, Invoicing & Revenue (5)	7.1 Types of contract · 7.2 Contract management · 7.3 Bills of quantities · 7.4 Invoicing and applications for payment · 7.5 Revenue recognition in the commercial cycle
D8 — Project Management Lifecycle (6)	8.1 Initiating · 8.2 Planning · 8.3 Executing · 8.4 Monitoring and controlling · 8.5 Closing · 8.6 Development approaches: predictive, iterative, incremental and adaptive
D9 — Agile, Scrum & Adaptive Delivery for Project Controls (6)	9.1 Agile foundations · 9.2 The Scrum framework in depth · 9.3 Backlogs, estimation and agile metrics · 9.4 Kanban, Lean and scaling · 9.5 Agile cost control, forecasting and earned value · 9.6 Hybrid delivery and agile governance
D10 — Project Scheduling (4)	10.1 Schedule development · 10.2 Network analysis and the critical path method · 10.3 Schedule compression and resourcing · 10.4 Progress measurement and schedule control
D11 — Business Process Cycles (3)	11.1 Order-to-cash · 11.2 Procure-to-pay · 11.3 Internal control and segregation of duties
D12 — Risk Management for Project Controls (3)	12.1 The risk framework · 12.2 The risk process · 12.3 Contingency and management reserve

Abbreviations used above and throughout: **BoQ** — bills of quantities; **EVM** — earned value management; **EAC** — estimate at completion.

5.3 Group 3 — AI knowledge & practical approach (20 %)

Seven knowledge areas in one domain, at a fifth of the examination.

Domain	Knowledge areas
D13 — AI for Project Controls & PM: Concepts, Tools & Practice (7)	13.1 AI foundations for professionals · 13.2 Data: the fuel · 13.3 Prompting and working with generative AI · 13.4 AI tool categories for project controls and project management · 13.5 AI applied across the project-controls lifecycle · 13.6 Governance, ethics, risk and assurance of AI · 13.7 Building an AI-augmented project-controls capability

The domain is vendor-neutral. Items test what a technique does, what it needs, where it fails and who is accountable for its output — never the interface of a particular product. A candidate who has learned one tool's menus has not prepared for this group.

6. How AI is examined

AI is not confined to Group 3. Two things are true at once, and candidates routinely prepare for only one of them.

Domain 13 carries the systematic treatment, at the published 20 per cent group weight: what the techniques are, what data they need, how they are governed, how they are assured, and how a capability is built. That is examined on its own terms.

Governed-AI judgement is also examinable inside the other two groups. Every domain in the body of knowledge carries embedded coverage of AI as it applies to that domain — automated cost coding in D1, predictive estimate-at-completion in D6, exception detection in D11, risk scoring in D12. An item in Group 1 or Group 2 may therefore put an AI-generated output in front of the candidate and ask what a competent professional does with it. Such an item is scored against the domain of its subject matter, not against Domain 13; a question about an AI-generated cost forecast is a cost-forecasting question.

The Institute's governing position runs through all of it: **AI proposes; the professional disposes.** No item will ever reward a candidate for accepting a machine output that is not explainable, validated and owned by a competent human. Several will penalise it.

7. Item format

7.1 Four options, one best answer

Every item is a four-option multiple-choice question with a single best answer. Most are scenario-based: a situation from controls work, the data needed to judge it, and four options that a competent practitioner would recognise as arguable. The task is usually not to spot a wrong number but to decide what to do next.

The format's strengths and its real limitations — what a single-best-answer item can and cannot measure, and why the Institute has chosen it anyway — are set out in `EXB-03 — Cognitive levels and item types`. Worked examples with a rationale for every option are in `EXB-08 — Sample items with rationale`.

7.2 Calculation items and the formula policy

Calculation items supply the data. They do not supply the method.

No formula sheet is provided in the examination. Candidates are expected to know the core relationships of the body of knowledge — the accounting equation, the earned value family and its variances and indices, the estimate-at-completion forms, variance decomposition, expected value — and, more importantly, to select the right one for the situation. Choosing between two defensible estimate-at-completion methods on the evidence in front of you is a substantial part of what the credential attests; handing the candidate a menu of formulae removes the assessment along with the memory load.

The Institute publishes a master formula sheet as **study material**. It is a preparation aid, not an examination aid.

8. Scoring

Scoring is **criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve.** Everyone who demonstrates the required standard passes, however many others do. There is no quota, no fixed proportion who succeed and no ranking against other candidates. A candidate's result reflects their performance against a published standard and nothing else — which is why the Institute publishes no pass rate as a target and would regard a pass rate managed towards a number as a governance failure.

Results are issued immediately on submission with a domain-level breakdown, so an unsuccessful candidate receives a map for targeted preparation rather than a bare verdict. A result placed under integrity review is a deliberate exception: it shows no score and no pass or fail outcome until the review concludes. That rule, and why it exists, is set out in `EXB-07 — Examination security and integrity` §5.

9. What is deliberately not yet fixed

The Institute is founding-stage. Two elements of this specification are genuinely open, and this document states them as open rather than inventing a figure that would later have to be quietly changed.

9.1 The number of items

No item count exists. There is no published number, no configured number and no working assumption being held back. **Item counts will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis** — a structured study, with practitioners, of the tasks the credential attests and their criticality and frequency. That study determines how many items each group needs to measure its content reliably, and therefore what the total is. Setting the count first and finding a justification afterwards is the failure mode; see `EXB-06 — Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority`.

Anyone quoting an item count for this examination is quoting something the Institute has not published.

9.2 The definitive passing standard

65 per cent is the platform's configured pass mark, and it is what the examination applies today. **The definitive standard will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study** — a documented, panel-based judgement of what a minimally competent PCL-AI holder must be able to do, expressed as a cut score on the assembled form. Both statements are true and both are published, because a configured value and a validated standard are different things, and a candidate is entitled to know which one they are being measured against.

If the study sets the standard somewhere other than 65 per cent, the Institute will say so, publish the study's method and panel composition, and apply the new standard from a stated date — not retrospectively. The method, the panel and the arithmetic are set out in `EXB-05 — Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark`.

9.3 What is not open

To be equally clear about the other direction: the duration, the item format, the cognitive levels, the group weighting, the domain and knowledge-area structure, the criterion-referenced scoring basis, the absence of a formula sheet and the three-year validity are all settled and published above. They are not provisional, and a change to any of them would be a new version of this blueprint under §12.

10. What this blueprint does not do

Honesty about a specification's limits is part of its value.

It sets no per-domain minimum. Weights attach to the three groups. There is no published per-domain percentage and no requirement to reach a threshold in each domain separately. The domain breakdown on a result is diagnostic information, not a set of sub-hurdles.

It is not an item list. The blueprint governs sampling. The items on any live form are secured content and are never published. The sample items in `EXB-08` are written for publication and are held apart from the live bank; see `EXB-07` §2.

It guarantees nothing about outcomes. Studying the blueprint is necessary and not sufficient. No preparation, from any provider or none, guarantees a pass. The certification decision is independent of whatever training a candidate did or did not take, and the Institute makes no representation about pass rates, salaries or employment outcomes.

It claims no recognition the Institute does not hold. The certification framework is developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles. PCI is **not accredited** by ANAB, IAS or any other ISO/IEC 17024 accreditation body, and this blueprint carries no governmental approval or university equivalence. Where our status is relevant, we state it plainly.

It is not the policy of record. Fees, booking windows, retakes, accommodations, conduct and appeals are governed by the published policies summarised in `CER-01`.

11. Using the blueprint as a revision plan

The weighting is a study budget, and most candidates spend it badly by revising what they enjoy.

Rate your own confidence, honestly, against each of the thirteen domains in §5 — not against the three group headings, which are too coarse to act on. Then allocate preparation time against the published group weights and your gaps, in that order. Three patterns recur.

Candidates from a finance or accounting background typically under-prepare Domains 8 to 10 — lifecycle, adaptive delivery and schedule logic. They can read a set of accounts and cannot read a network.

Candidates from a planning background typically under-prepare Domains 1 to 4. The 40 per cent accounting and finance group is the largest single gap among practitioners who came up through scheduling, and it is the one most often discovered too late.

Almost every candidate under-prepares Domain 13 relative to its weight, because it feels peripheral to the day job. At the published weighting, one scored item in five sits in the AI group before any embedded coverage elsewhere is counted. Treating it as a topic to skim is the most expensive study decision available.

Practise across domains rather than within them. Examination scenarios cross domain boundaries deliberately — a schedule slip has cost, commercial, risk and reporting consequences, and an item may ask about any of them — so revising each domain in isolation prepares you for a form that does not exist.

12. Versioning and change

This blueprint is maintained under PCI governance alongside the body of knowledge.

A **minor version** corrects, clarifies or adds explanation without changing what is examined or how it is weighted. A **major version** changes the sampling frame, the weighting, the format, the cognitive levels or the scoring basis, and is published with a stated effective date and a notice period.

Candidates are assessed only against the edition of the blueprint in force for their sitting. A change published after a candidate books does not apply to that sitting unless it is applied in the candidate's favour. The effective date of this edition and the date of the first live sitting are [CONFIRM: effective date of this blueprint edition and the date of the first live sitting].

13. Candidate self-audit checklist

Take this into your revision planning, not into the examination.

- [ ] I can name all thirteen domains and say which of the three groups each belongs to.
- [ ] I have rated my confidence against each of the sixty-one knowledge areas in §5, not just the domains.
- [ ] My revision time is allocated 40/40/20 against the groups, adjusted for my weakest areas — not for my favourites.
- [ ] I can compute the earned value family, its variances and indices, and at least three estimate-at-completion forms without a reference sheet, and say when each is appropriate.
- [ ] I can read a contract type and state who carries cost-overrun risk on defined scope.
- [ ] I can build and read a critical path, compute total float, and say what happens when float is exceeded.
- [ ] I can explain how revenue recognition, billing and the cost report relate to one another on a single contract.
- [ ] I can describe what a machine-learning model needs from project data before it is any use, and what happens when it does not get it.
- [ ] For any AI-generated output, I can state how I would establish that it is explainable, validated and owned.
- [ ] I have practised at least one scenario that crosses three domains and answered it under time pressure.
- [ ] I have read `EXB-07` and know what conduct will put a result under integrity review.

Related

- `EXB-02 — Domain weightings and the 40/40/20 rule` — why the weighting is what it is, and exactly what a group weight does to a score
- `EXB-03 — Cognitive levels and item types` — what Recall, Application and Analysis mean here, and the limits of the four-option format
- `EXB-06 — Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority` — the study that will fix the item counts this document leaves open
- `EXB-08 — Sample items with rationale` — the format worked in full, with every option explained
- `CER-01 — Certification handbook — master` — eligibility, booking, conduct, results and appeals: everything §1.1 puts outside this blueprint

- `PCB-02 — The thirteen domains at a glance` — the same structure read as a body of knowledge rather than as a sampling frame

Sources and standards

The domain and knowledge-area structure in §5 is taken from the PCI Body of Knowledge (`docs/bok/`), which is the source of truth for content; this document reproduces its structure, not its text. The examination parameters in §3 are the Institute's configured platform settings as verified in August 2026.

Standards named in the syllabus — IFRS and IAS reporting standards, the AACE International total cost management framework, PMBOK, ISO 31000, the Agile Manifesto and the Scrum Guide, and ISO/IEC 17024 — are referenced by name and explained in the Institute's own words throughout the body of knowledge. No protected text, table, diagram or item bank from any of them is reproduced.

No external citation is claimed for this document.

Status and version

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